Q+A

Measured Pace

Pankaj Tripathi is back as Kaleen Bhaiya in *Mirzapur: The Movie*



Q It's not every day a web series gets a theatrical film. Is it proof that *Mirzapur* is as big as it gets?

Totally. For something in long format and OTT to be so popular globally, particularly its characters, and for its canvas to be big, makes it ideal for the big screen. The makers thought people were experiencing it individually, so why not give it a community viewing?

Q Does *Criminal Justice*'s Madhav Mishra, the other popular character you play on OTT, have potential for the big screen?

For sure. Madhav Mishra's survival instinct is amazing. You can't ignore Kaleen Bhaiya in a crowd of thousands; Madhav Mishra you can't notice in the same scenario. He can be in any situation and get the work done. There's a sense of humour that binds both the characters. Looks-wise, too, they are similar. There's a difference in dialogue delivery, though, with Madhav Mishra not being as authoritative as Kaleen Bhaiya.

Q *Mirzapur, Criminal Justice, Stree*... you have appeared in some of the biggest franchises.

I am full of gratitude. *Main toh aaya tha* cinema *mein* career *banane, lekin Ishwar ne toh* franchise *hi bana diya*. I wanted to do small work which would help me survive and look after my family. It's thanks to my hard work and the trust of filmmakers and audiences that I have made it this far.

Q What's next?

I have *Parivarik Manoranjan*, a streaming film. *Itminaan se kaam kar raha hoon*, doing one project at a time. The artist in me seeks to devote my body, soul and intellect into each work I do. I couldn't until now. I would shuttle between film sets. This slow exploratory approach is possible because I have earned the audience's trust and there's no EMI pressure. Without such burdens, the artist is at ease.

—with ***Suhani Singh***

Photograph by SANKHADEEP BANERJEE